

World Cup Workers Say: 'We Might Strike!' Here's Why

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Picture this: you're at the biggest soccer game ever, but the people selling snacks and cleaning up might walk off the job! That's what could happen at SoFi Stadium in Los Angeles, where the U.S. team plays its first World Cup match on June 12. Workers there like cashiers, cooks, and bartenders voted 96% to go on **strike** if they don't get what they're asking for. Their **union**, UNITE HERE Local 11, says they want higher pay and to feel safe at work. One big worry? **Immigration officers**. Some workers are afraid that **ICE agents** might show up at the games and cause trouble for their families. A worker named Yolanda Fierro said, "No worker should have to fear being separated from their family." The **union** wants **FIFA** to promise that immigration agents won't be at the stadium. But the government says agents will be there only for security, not to arrest people for immigration issues. The company that runs the stadium, Legends Global, says they're talking and want a fair deal. **Negotiations** are happening right now. If they don't agree soon, workers could **strike** at any moment. That would be a huge deal with fans from all over the world watching. Let's hope they figure it out so everyone can just enjoy the beautiful game!

Word Treasure

strike -- When workers refuse to work as a protest to get better pay or conditions.

union -- A group that workers join to bargain together for fair treatment.

immigration officers -- Government workers who check if people are allowed to live and work in the country.

ICE agents -- Special officers who enforce immigration laws; ICE stands for Immigration and Customs Enforcement.

FIFA -- The big organization that runs the World Cup and makes soccer rules worldwide.

negotiations -- Formal talks between two sides to try to reach an agreement.

Background you need

SoFi Stadium (a huge sports stadium in Los Angeles) will be one of the places for the 2026 World Cup.

Workers at stadiums often join unions, like UNITE HERE Local 11, so they can ask for fair pay and safety together.

Some workers are worried about ICE (Immigration and Customs Enforcement), which is the agency that checks people's immigration status.

Break it down

WHO: Cashiers, cooks, bartenders, and the union UNITE HERE Local 11

WHAT: They voted 96% to go on strike for better pay and a promise that immigration agents won't be at the stadium

WHERE: SoFi Stadium in Los Angeles, where the U.S. plays on June 12

WHY: Workers are worried about low wages and that ICE agents could cause trouble for their families

Why it matters

The people who work at games help make the fun happen, so if you go to a big event, remember that workers deserve fair treatment too.

Test what you remember

1. Where is SoFi Stadium?

- ☐ (A) New York
- ☐ (B) Los Angeles
- ☐ (C) Dallas
- ☐ (D) Miami

2. What percentage of workers voted to strike?

- ☐ (A) 50%
- ☐ (B) 75%
- ☐ (C) 96%
- ☐ (D) 100%

3. What does the union want from FIFA?

- ☐ (A) More snacks
- ☐ (B) Promise no immigration agents at stadium
- ☐ (C) Free tickets
- ☐ (D) Air conditioning

4. What does the government say about ICE agents at the stadium?

- ☐ (A) They'll arrest everyone
- ☐ (B) They'll be there only for security
- ☐ (C) They won't come
- ☐ (D) They'll give free water

5. Who runs the stadium?

- ☐ (A) FIFA
- ☐ (B) Legends Global
- ☐ (C) UNITE HERE
- ☐ (D) SoFi

6. When is the U.S. team's first World Cup match?

- ☐ (A) June 1
- ☐ (B) June 12
- ☐ (C) July 4
- ☐ (D) Not decided

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. **Workers' fight for fairness:** The cashiers and cooks say they need higher wages and a safe workplace without fear of immigration agents.
2. **Stadium's promise:** Legends Global, the stadium operator, says they want a fair deal and are negotiating with the union to avoid a strike.
3. **Government's role:** The government claims ICE agents are only there to keep everyone safe, not to arrest families, but workers don't trust that promise.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):